

Barney G. Glaser / Anselm L. Strauss

THE DISCOVERY OF GROUNDED THEORY



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THE DISCOVERY OF GROUNDED THEORY

strategies for qualitative research

Barney G. Glaser
Anselm L. Strauss

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Preface

Mentioning the Department of Sociology at Columbia University brings to mind Merton's middle-range theory and Lazarsfeld's quantitative methodology. On the other hand, the "Chicago tradition" (from the 1920's to the 1950's) is associated with down-to-earth qualitative research, a less than rigorous methodology, and an unintegrated presentation of theory. By an ironic conjunction of careers, the authors of this book were trained, respectively, at Columbia and Chicago. The point is noted only to emphasize our conviction that neither of these traditions—nor any other in postwar sociology—has been successful at closing the embarrassing gap between theory and empirical research. The gap is as wide today as it was in 1941, when Blumer commented on it, and in 1949, when Merton optimistically suggested a solution.

Attempts to close the gap between theory and research have concentrated principally on the improvement of methods for testing theory, and sociologists, as well as other social and behavioral scientists, have been quite successful in that endeavor. Attempts to close the gap from the "theory side" have not been nearly so successful. In fact, "grand theory" is still so influential and prevalent that for many researchers it is synonymous with "theory"—and so they think of "theory" as having little relevance to their research. They have resolutely continued to focus on their empirical studies and on their efforts to improve the methodology of verification.

Our book is directed toward improving social scientists' capacities for generating theory that *will* be relevant to their re-

search. Not everyone can be equally skilled at discovering theory, but neither do they need to be a genius to generate useful theory. What is required, we believe, is a different perspective on the canons derived from vigorous quantitative verification on such issues as sampling, coding, reliability, validity, indicators, frequency distributions, conceptual formulation, construction of hypotheses, and presentation of evidence. We need to develop canons more suited to the discovery of theory. These guides, along with associated rules of procedure, can help release energies for theorizing that are now frozen by the undue emphasis on verification.

We argue in our book for grounding theory in social research itself—for generating it from the data. We have linked this position with a general method of comparative analysis—different from the more specific comparative methods now current —and with various procedures designed to generate grounded theory. Although our emphasis is on generating theory rather than verifying it, we take special pains not to divorce those two activities, both necessary to the scientific enterprise. Although our book is directed primarily at sociologists, we believe it can be useful to anyone who is interested in studying social phenomena—political, educational, economic, industrial, or whatever—especially if their studies are based on qualitative data.

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We wish to express our indebtedness to many colleagues for their general support of our total enterprise, their encouragement for its publication, and their specific commentaries and critiques, which we found invaluable for final revisions of the manuscript. Their comments indicated clearly that, while in general agreement, these colleagues felt in some controversy with us on several specific issues—issues that will doubtless be controversial in sociology for years to come. In short, we have taken their advice and support, but at the same time are fully responsible for our own position.

We wish to thank Howard S. Becker of Northwestern University, editor of the "Observations" series; Fred Davis and Leonard Schatzman of the University of California at San Francisco; Julius Roth of the University of California at Davis; Amitai Etzioni and Walter Klink of Columbia University; Herbert Blumer, Neil J. Smelser, Sheldon Messinger, and Aaron Cicourel of the University of California at Berkeley; George C.

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B. G. G. and A. L. S.

I

The Discovery of Grounded Theory

Most writing on sociological method has been concerned with how accurate facts can be obtained and how theory can thereby be more rigorously tested. In this book we address ourselves to the equally important enterprise of *how the discovery of theory from data—systematically obtained and analyzed in social research—can be furthered.* We believe that the discovery of theory from data—which we call *grounded theory*—is a major task confronting sociology today, for, as we shall try to show, such a theory fits empirical situations, and is understandable to sociologists and layman alike. Most important, it works—provides us with relevant predictions, explanations, interpretations and applications.

As sociologists engaged in research soon discover, there are as yet few theories of this nature. And so we offer this book, which we conceive as a beginning venture in the development of improved methods for discovering grounded theory. Because this is only a beginning, we shall often state positions, counter-positions and examples, rather than offering clear-cut procedures and definitions, because at many points we believe our slight knowledge makes any formulation premature. A major strategy that we shall emphasize for furthering the discovery of grounded theory is a *general method of comparative analysis.*

Previous books on methods of social research have focused mainly on how to verify theories. This suggests an overemphasis in current sociology on the verification of theory, and a

resultant de-emphasis on the prior step of discovering what concepts and hypotheses are relevant for the area that one wishes to research. Testing theory is, of course, also a basic task confronting sociology. We would all agree that in social research generating theory goes hand in hand with verifying it; but many sociologists have been diverted from this truism in their zeal to test either existing theories or a theory that they have barely started to generate.

Surely no conflict between verifying and generating theory is logically necessary during the course of any given research. For many sociologists, however, undoubtedly there exists a conflict concerning primacy of purpose, reflecting the opposition between a desire to generate theory and a trained need to verify it. Since verification has primacy on the current sociological scene, the desire to generate theory often becomes secondary, if not totally lost, in specific researches.

Our book—especially when we discuss the current emphasis on verification—will indicate many facets and forms that the resolution of this conflict takes among sociologists, but this discussion should not be taken as indicating that we endorse the existence of such a conflict. Rather, our position is that a conflict is created when sociologists do not clearly and consciously choose which will receive relative emphasis in given researches because of too great an adherence to verification as the chief mandate for excellent research.

Grounded Theory

The basic theme in our book is the discovery of theory from data systematically obtained from social research.[1] Every chapter deals with our beginning formulation of some of the processes

1. Merton never reached the notion of the discovery of grounded theory in discussing the "theoretic functions of research." The closest he came was with "serendipity"; that is, an unanticipated, anomalous, and strategic finding gives rise to a new hypothesis. This concept does not catch the idea of purposefully discovering theory through social research. It puts the discovery of a single hypothesis on a surprise basis. Merton was preoccupied with how verifications through research feed back into and modify theory. Thus, he was concerned with grounded modifying of theory, not grounded generating of theory. *Social Theory and Social Structure* (Glencoe, 111.: Free Press, 1949), Chapter III.

of research for generating theory. Our basic position is that generating grounded theory is a way of arriving at theory suited to its supposed uses. We shall contrast this position with theory generated by logical deduction from *a priori* assumptions. In Chapter II we shall discuss what we mean by theory and compare it with other conceptions of theory.

The interrelated jobs of theory in sociology are: (1) to enable prediction and explanation of behavior; (2) to be useful in theoretical advance in sociology; (3) to be usable in practical applications—prediction and explanation should be able to give the practitioner understanding and some control of situations; (4) to provide a perspective on behavior—a stance to be taken toward data; and (5) to guide and provide a style for research on particular areas of behavior. Thus theory in sociology is a strategy for handling data in research, providing modes of conceptualization for describing and explaining. The theory should provide clear enough categories and hypotheses so that crucial ones can be verified in present and future research; they must be clear enough to be readily operationalized in quantitative studies when these are appropriate.[2] The theory must also be readily understandable to sociologists of any viewpoint, to students and to significant laymen. Theory that can meet these requirements must fit the situation being researched, and work when put into use. By "fit" we mean that the categories must be readily (not forcibly) applicable to and indicated by the data under study; by "work" we mean that they must be meaningfully relevant to and be able to explain the behavior under study.

To generate theory that fills this large order, we suggest as the best approach an initial, systematic discovery of the theory from the data of social research. Then one can be relatively sure that the theory will fit and work.[3] And since the categories are discovered by examination of the data, laymen involved in the area to which the theory applies will usually be able to under-

2. In principle any concept can be operationalized in quantitative ways, but the sociologist should develop his concepts to facilitate this operationalization.

3. Of course, the researcher does not approach reality as a *tabula rasa*. He must have a perspective that will help him see relevant data and ab stract significant categories from his scrutiny of the data. We shall discuss this issue more fully in Chapters II and XI.

stand it, while sociologists who work in other areas will recognize an understandable theory linked with the data of a given area.

Theory based on data can usually not be completely refuted by more data or replaced by another theory. Since it is too intimately linked to data, it is destined to last despite its inevitable modification and reformulation. The most striking examples are Weber's theory of bureaucracy and Durkheim's theory of suicide. These theories have endured for decades, stimulating a variety of research and study, constantly exciting students and professors alike to try to modify them by clever ways of testing and reformulation. In contrast, logically deduced theories based on ungrounded assumptions, such as some well-known ones on the "social system" and on "social action" can lead their followers far astray in trying to advance sociology.[4] However, grounded theories—which take hard study of much data—are worth the precious time and focus of all of us in our research, study and teaching.

Grounded theory can help to forestall the opportunistic use of theories that have dubious fit and working capacity. So often in journals we read a highly empirical study which at its conclusion has a tacked-on explanation taken from a logically deduced theory. The author tries to give his data a more general sociological meaning, as well as to account for or interpret what he found. He uses this strategy because he has not been trained to generate a theory from the data he is reporting so that it will help interpret or explain the data in a general manner. He does this also because he has been trained only to research and verify his facts, not also to research and generate his explanation of them. The explanation is added afterward. For instance, many papers dealing with deviance conclude with an interpretation based on Merton's anomie theory, a classic example of this use of logically deduced theory. An author could, of course, borrow the grounded theory of another sociologist for its general relevance, but—since this kind of theory fits and works—it would readily be seen whether it is clearly applicable and relevant in this new situation. It cannot be tenu-

4. And also in trying to advance their personal careers, for one cannot empirically dissociate the need to generate theory from the need to advance careers in sociology.

ously connected, omitting of many other possible explanations, as a tacked-on explanation so often is.

Another opportunistic use of theory that cannot occur with grounded theory is what may be termed "exampling." A researcher can easily find examples for dreamed-up, speculative, or logically deduced theory after the idea has occurred. But since the idea has not been derived from the example, seldom can the example correct or change it (even if the author is willing), since the example was selectively chosen for its confirming power. Therefore, one receives the image of a proof when there is none, and the theory obtains a richness of detail that it did not earn.

There is also a middle zone between grounded and logico-deductive theorizing, in which the sociologist chooses examples systematically and then allows them to feed back to give theoretical control over his formulations; but often it is hard to figure out when this is happening, even when we are clearly told. Much of C. Wright Mills' work, we believe, is exampled with only little theoretical control, though he claimed that data disciplined his theory. In contrast, grounded theory is derived from data and then illustrated by characteristic examples of data.[5]

In contrasting grounded theory with logico-deductive theory and discussing and assessing their relative merits in ability to fit and work (predict, explain, and be relevant), we have taken the position that the adequacy of a theory for sociology today cannot be divorced from the process by which it is generated. Thus one canon for judging the usefulness of a theory is how it was generated—and we suggest that it is likely to be a better theory to the degree that it has been inductively developed from social research. We also believe that other canons for assessing a theory, such as logical consistency, clarity, parsimony, density, scope, integration, as well as its fit and its ability to work, are also significantly dependent on how the theory was generated. They are not, as some theorists of a logico-deductive persuasion would claim, completely independent of the processes of generation. This notion of independence too often ends up being taken as a license to generate theory from any source—

5. See, for example, Howard S. Becker *et al., Boys in White* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1961).

happenstance, fantasy, dream life, common sense, or conjecture —and then dress it up as a bit of logical deduction.

Probably we need to emphasize here what we shall discuss later more explicitly. Generating a theory from data means that most hypotheses and concepts not only come from the data, but are systematically worked out in relation to the data during the course of the research. *Generating a theory involves a process of research.* By contrast, the *source* of certain ideas, or even "models," can come from sources other than the data. The biographies of scientists are replete with stories of occasional flashes of insight, of seminal ideas, garnered from sources outside the data. But the generation of theory from such insights must then be brought into relation to the data, or there is great danger that theory and empirical world will mismatch. We shall discuss this issue again more fully, particularly in Chapter XI on "Insight, Theory Development, and Reality."

For many colleagues, our position will be at best a hypothesis, to be tested in the years to come; while for many others it is proven fact, and for still others an article of faith. However colleagues may respond, our position is not logical; it is phenomenological. We could not suggest a process of generating theory if we did not believe that people who might use it would arrive at results that potentially may be judged as successful. Furthermore, we believe that grounded theory will be more successful than theories logically deduced from *a priori* assumptions. Our position, we hasten to add, does not at all imply that the generation of new theory should proceed in isolation from existing grounded theory. (We shall discuss this in Chapter II.)

Purposes of This Book

This book is intended to underscore the basic sociological activity that *only* sociologists can do: generating sociological theory. Description, ethnography, fact-finding, verification (call them what you will) are all done well by professionals in other fields and by layman in various investigatory agencies. But these people cannot generate sociological theory from their

work. Only sociologists are trained to want it, to look for it, and to generate it.

Besides reminding colleagues of a somewhat slighted task, we also are trying, through this book, to strengthen the mandate for generating theory, to help provide a defense against doctrinaire approaches to verification, and to reawaken and broaden the picture of what sociologists can do with their time and efforts. It should also help students to defend themselves against verifiers who would teach them to deny the validity of their own scientific intelligence. By making generation a legitimate enterprise, and suggesting methods for it, we hope to provide the ingredients of a defense against internalized professional mandates dictating that sociologists research and write in the verification rhetoric, and against the protests of colleagues who object to their freedom in research from the rigorous rules of verification (so stifling to the creative energies required for discovering theory).

In trying to stimulate all sociologists to discover grounded theory—from those who are only at the dissertation stage of their careers to those who are already "retired" professors—we hope to contribute toward the equalizing of efforts in generating theory, which are now often limited to the earlier stages of a sociological career. For example, Hammon, in presenting us with chronicles of some of the best sociological research (those with the highest theoretical yield), has chosen mainly chronicles of dissertations or studies done as soon as the dissertation was finished.[6] Similar studies could be done by mature sociologists, and with more speed (less fumbling, clearer purpose) and more sophisticated theoretical yields. Indeed, that the growth of a theorist is linked to the increasing sophistication of his output is clearly seen in the work of men like Goffman, Lipset and Wilbert Moore. Yet many sociologists as they mature disregard whatever fledgling potential for generating theory they showed in their dissertations and early monographs. They cease or slow up their research and writing of monographs and turn to scholarship and the mastery of others' works, particularly earlier "great man" theories. One respected scholar, by

6. Philip E. Hammond (Ed.), *Sociologists at Work* (New York: Basic Books, 1964).

virtue of his position and prominence, has encouraged this trend, by saying, in effect, at a recent sociological meeting, that he would like to see older sociologists cease writing their monographs and start worrying about teaching the next generation of students. We urge them to continue writing monographs and to try to generate theory!

Throughout this book we call for more theory, but not just any theory. The general comparative method for generating grounded theory that will be discussed in Part I provides criteria for judging the worth of all theory, as well as grounded theory. This theme pervades the whole book. It is our intent to give colleagues an effective means for evaluating the worth of any theory that they will teach, apply or use in research, for describing, explaining, predicting, interpreting and testing.

What about this book's usefulness for those sociologists who already are deeply involved in generating theory? Many may be able to use it effectively to help systematize their theorizing; for until they proceed with a bit more method their theories will tend to end up thin, unclear in purpose, and not well integrated (see Chapter VI). Our suggestions for systematizing should not curb anyone's creativity for generating theory; in contrast to the ways of verification, they should encourage it. Our strategies do not insist that the analyst engage in a degree of explicitness and overdrawn explanation in an effort to coerce the theory's acceptance by "drugging the reader's imagination and beating him into intellectual submission."[7] Our suggestions for systematizing the rendition of theory allow, even demand, room for including both propositions and the richness of information leading to them.[8]

Our principal aim is to stimulate other theorists to codify and publish their *own* methods for generating theory. We trust that they will join us in telling those who have not yet attempted to generate theory that it is not a residual chore in this age of verification. Though difficult, it is an exciting adventure.

In our own attempt to discuss methods and processes for discovering grounded theory, we shall, for the most part, keep

7. Melville Dalton, "Preconceptions in Methods in Men Who Manage," in Hammond, *op. cit.,* pp. 57-58.

8. Compare to Merton's strictures on codification of theory, which require leaving out the "irrelevant" richness of connotation! *Op. cit.,* p. 14.

the discussion open-minded, to stimulate rather than freeze thinking about the topic. Our suggestions are deliberately interspersed with occasional frank polemic—always, we hope, with purpose—though not at the expense of stopping the flow of suggested procedures or the logic lying behind them. In using examples from research, we have drawn heavily upon our own work—and for a very good reason. We know others' work as published product; we know our own better as work-in-process—and discovering *theory as a process* is, of course, the central theme of this book.

In the first section—*Comparative Analysis*—we shall present a strategy whereby sociologists can facilitate the discovery of grounded theory, both substantive and formal. This strategy involves the systematic choice and study of several comparison groups. In Chapter II we discuss the purpose of our use of comparative analysis. In Chapter III we discuss theoretical sampling—the process of collecting data for comparative analysis designed to generate substantive and formal theory. In Chapter IV we take up the transition from substantive to formal theory. And in Chapter V we offer our method for the comparative analysis of qualitative data. In Chapter VI we clarify and assess a number of previous comparative studies in terms of several important questions.

In the second part of the book—*The Flexible Use of Data*— we consider in detail the generation of theory from qualitative (especially documentary) and quantitative data (in Chapters VII and VII, respectively).

In the third part of the book—*Implications of Grounded Theory*—we consider the credibility of grounded theory (Chapter IX) and its practical implications (Chapter X). Lastly, in Chapter XI we discuss insight, theory development and reality. We close with an epilogue summarizing our position on the relations of theory to research.

Before moving on to these chapters, we shall discuss the contemporary emphasis on verification, the influential style of logico-deductive theorizing, which encourages the drive toward verification, and the distinction usually drawn between qualitative and quantitative data—a distinction useless for the generation of theory.

Verification and "Grand" Theory

Verification of theory is the keynote of current sociology. Some three decades ago, it was felt that we had plenty of theories but few confirmations of them—a position made very feasible by the greatly increased sophistication of quantitative methods.[9] As this shift in emphasis took hold, the discovery of new theories became slighted and, at some universities, virtually neglected. Those who still wished to generate theory had to brook the negative, sometimes punitive, attitudes of their colleagues or professors.

Part of the trend toward emphasizing verification was the assumption by many sociologists that our "great men" forefathers (Weber, Durkheim, Simmel, Marx, Veblen, Cooley, Mead, Park, etc.) had generated a sufficient number of outstanding theories on enough areas of social life to last for a long while. Although we, their sociological offspring, could never equal their genius, we did know how to modify and reformulate their theories with our new-found abilities in verification—and so that was the next job of sociology. As a result, many of our teachers converted departments of sociology into mere repositories of "great-man" theories and taught these theories with a charismatic finality that students could seldom resist. Currently, students are trained to master great-man theories and to test them in small ways, but hardly to question the theory as a whole in terms of its position or manner of generation. As a result many potentially creative students have limited themselves to puzzling out small problems bequeathed to them in big theories. A few men (like Parsons and Merton) have seen through this charismatic view of the great men sufficiently to generate "grand" theories on their own. But even these few have lacked methods for generating theory from data, or at any rate have not written about their methods. They have played "theoretical capitalist" to the mass of "proletariat" testers,

9. See Hans L. Zetterberg, *On Theory and Verification in Sociology* (Totowa, N.J.: Bedminster Press, 1963).

by training young sociologists to test their teachers' work but *not* to imitate it.[10]

In the face of this prevalent attitude, we contend, however, that the masters have not provided enough theories to cover all the areas of social life that sociologists have only begun to explore. Further, some theories of our predecessors, because of their lack of grounding in data, do not fit, or do not work, or are not' sufficiently understandable to be used and are therefore useless in research, theoretical advance and practical application. On the other hand, the great theorists have indeed given us models and guidelines for generating theory, so that with recent advances in data collection, conceptual systematization and analytic procedures, many of us can follow in their paths: from social research we can generate theories for new areas, as well as better theories for areas where previous ones do not work.[11]

We contend also that it does not take a "genius" to generate a useful grounded theory. It does take some codification of the method of doing it, as well as recognition of its legitimacy for student training and academic careers. Our book provides some of both. It is well known that in science the highest rewards have always gone to those who generate an important new

10. The following are the words of a young theoretical capitalist modestly asking the proletariat testers to correct his conjectured the ory: "Whereas empirical tests would undoubtedly prove a good proportion of the inferred predictions to be incorrect, these negative findings would provide a basis for refining the theory, whereas as no such refinements are possible if a theory fails to yield operational hypotheses that can be negated by empirical evidence." Thus to encourage the testers he carefully writes his theory so it can be readily operationalized and proven wrong in several ways—a temptation for those who like to prove the theorist wrong. These proletariat testers do not realize that allowing themselves to be tempted sim ply puts the refined theory and the theorist on firmer ground, while they are soon forgotten. See Peter Blau, *Exchange and Power in Social Life* (New York: John Wiley and Sons, 1964), p. 9. We can only say that it is our position that theorists be responsible for the grounding of their theories from the start.

For another attempt at theoretical capitalism and request for colleagues to test him out, see Thomas J. Scheff, *Being Mentally Ill* (Chicago: Aldine Publishing Co., 1966), especially p. 101.

11. For example, this is happening in the study of deviance. See Marshall B. Clinard (Ed.), *Anomie and Deviant Behavior* (New York: Free Press of Glencoe, 1964).

theory (sociology *is* like physics in this regard).[12] Historical reasons, then, account for the paradox that more sociologists do not try their hand at generating theory and publishing it, thus achieving high rewards. We wish to help alleviate this condition by encouraging able sociologists to generate more and better theory with the type of comparative method discussed in our book, and, in turn, to start developing methods of their own for all of us to use.

Verification or Generation?

The following account is an example of the kind of historical circumstance that put the generation of grounded theory into second place, and made verification the dominant orientation in virtually all sociological work:

During 1938 the Social Science Research Council struck upon the idea of subjecting to critical appraisal a series of significant contributions to social science. In sociology, Herbert Blumer was assigned the task of appraising Thomas and Znani-ecki's great monograph, *The Polish Peasant in Poland and America.*[13] A year later Blumer's critique was published by the Council.[14] The volume included comments on Blumer's analysis by Thomas and by Znaniecki, as well as a reprinting of the proceedings of a conference that discussed the analysis (the conference included such participants as Murdock, Wirth, Bain, Wiley and Waller).

Blumer noted that Thomas and Znaniecki had been much concerned with methodological issues and had taken a stand against several types of knowledge then much advocated. These latter included "common sense generalization," "planless empiricism," "mere statements of uniformities of social behavior in response to social influences," "statements of causal influences which hold true 'on the average,' or 'in a majority of cases,'" and a type of misleading oversimplification in which "effort is made to resolve what must be taken as a primary relation into

12. For example, six of the eight Maclver Awards have gone to sociologists for generating grounded theory.

13. Thomas and F. Znaniecki (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1918).

14. Appraisal of Thomas and Znaniecki's *The Polish Peasant in Europe and America* (New York: Social Science Research Council, 1939).

simpler elements." In contrast, the monograph was directed at furthering general sociological theory and giving a very detailed interpretation of Polish peasant society in Europe and America.

Blumer's principal criticism of *The Polish Peasant* was directed at what he believed was an important methodological flaw in it—one that needed to be discussed as an issue basic to sociological research rather than as pertinent merely to this particular monograph. The authors claimed that their analyses rested largely on numerous "human documents": letters, agency records, life histories, court records. Blumer noted first that not all—perhaps not even the major—theoretical conceptions used by Thomas and Znaniecki were grounded on those documents. Indeed, "the major outlines are foreshadowed in the previous writings of Thomas," and even "their *particular* interpretations of Polish peasant life were not formed solely from the materials they present; we have to assume that the familiarity with Polish peasant life which enabled their interpretations was made in a wide variety of ways."

But this was only a minor criticism. Blumer's major concern was this: "the important question is whether the materials adequately test the generalizations (regardless of their source) which are being applied to the materials. . . ." But "the answer is very inconclusive." Some interpretations seemed to him to be borne out by the materials; some did not. Worse yet, usually one could not say that "the interpretation is either true or not, even though it is distinctly plausible," (pp. 74-75). Blumer agreed that these plausible interpretations made the materials more significant and made "theoretical interpretation more understandable." Yet the very puzzling issue of plausible interpretation versus genuine verification remained.

Therefore Blumer concluded, first, that the materials were not a decisive test of theoretical interpretations, although they did more than simply illustrate them; second, that a test of "theory would have to come in other ways, such as in its internal consistency, in the character of its assumptions, in its relation to other theories, in its consistency with what seems to be 'human,' or in other kinds of data than those provided by human documents"; and, third, that the authors' use of human documents would seemingly imply that their essential function "would be to ... yield to a sensitive and inquiring mind

hunches, insights, questions suitable for reflection, new perspectives, and new understandings" (pp. 75-76). In short, the data were useful for theorizing but not adequate for verification.

Blumer's critique was written during the period when Stouffer, Chapin, Lazarsfeld, Guttman and other advocates of better (quantitative) measures for checking theory began to exert great influence in sociology. The emphasis in Blumer's critique on verification, then, fit the mood of the day. Yet the enormous influence of *The Polish Peasant* for two decades was less the result of its demonstrable findings than of its stimulating theory. With hindsight, we can wonder what might have happened if Blumer had focused less on the problem of verification and more on generation. He did, of course, come close to emphasizing the latter, since he raised the issue of how to theorize from data rather than from the armchair. But, as we see it, whatever his intent, Blumer threw the weight of his analysis toward an examination of verification, rather than toward the question of how to generate grounded theory. He left that latter problem largely untouched, apparently assuming that the most one could say was that good theory is produced by a fortunate combination—an inquiring mind, rich experience, and stimulating data.[15]

Znaniecki's rejoinder to Blumer's critique on the verification issue is also instructive. He agreed that his monograph's materials did not always provide a good test of the theoretical formulations, but he attributed this to "the inadequacy of that general conceptual framework with which we approached our data."

15. A year later, Blumer published an admirable article addressing himself to the gap between ungrounded theories and the countless empirical studies unguided by any theories. Operationalism was then coming into dominance, and he attacked it effectively as not offering a solution to closing the gap. Closing it, he believed, would depend on "developing a rich and intimate familiarity with the kind of conduct being studied and in employing whatever relevant imagination observers may fortunately possess. The improvement in judgment, in observation, and in concept will be in the future, as . . . in the past, a slow maturing process." His emphases on the meaning of the theory-data gap and on the requisite need for good qualitative data, we agree with thoroughly. Blumer's solution to getting better theory, and in close relation to data, was—again—blunted because he was poised in too sharp a posture against verification (Operationalism in this instance), and too ready to give up on the problem of how to generate better theory except by the general formula of sticking close to the data being studied. See his "The Problem of the Concept in Social Psychology," *American Journal of Sociology* (1940), 707-19; the quotes are from pp. 718-19.

By "framework," Znaniecki referred to the "excessive simplicity of the 'attitude-value' conceptual combinations"—the principal theoretical conception that organized the monograph. Znaniecki would substitute a more sophisticated conception involving "system" and "pattern" (which he believed had been implicit anyhow in the monograph) which would have demanded fuller qualitative data of various kinds. He was still thinking of the generation of theory largely in terms of a pre-existent conceptualization; he was still not emphasizing methods for generating *grounded* theory.

Qualitative vs. Quantitative Data

Historically linked with the change in relative emphasis from generation to verification of theory was the clash between advocates of quantitative and qualitative data. The generators of theory in the late 1930's, by and large, had used qualitative data in a nonsystematic and nonrigorous way (when they used data at all), in conjunction with their own logic and common sense. In addition, monographs based on qualitative data consisted of lengthy, detailed descriptions which resulted in very small amounts of theory, if any.[16] The effort in these monographs was to "get the story straight." In short, the work based on qualitative data was either not theoretical enough or the theories were too "impressionistic."

Meanwhile, beginning in the late 1930's, and especially after World War II, quantitative researchers made great strides both in producing accurate evidence and in translating theoretical concepts into research operations. The result was an ability to begin the challenge of testing theory rigorously.

Thus, advances in quantitative methods initiated the zeal to test unconfirmed theories with the "facts." Qualitative research, because of its poor showing in producing the scientifically reproducible fact, and its sensitivity in picking up everyday facts about social structures and social systems, was relegated, by men like Stouffer and Lazarsfeld, to preliminary, exploratory, groundbreaking work for getting surveys started. Qualitative research was to provide quantitative research with a few sub-

16. For example, see the various studies of the Chicago school on the gang, the ghetto, the taxi-dance hall, the hoboes, etc.

stantive categories and hypotheses. Then, of course, quantitative research would take over, explore further, discover facts and test current theory.

The strength of this position, which soon swept over American sociology, was based on the emerging systematic canons and rules of evidence of quantitative analysis: on such issues as sampling, coding, reliability validity, indicators, frequency distributions, conceptual formulization, hypothesis construction, and parsimonious presentation of evidence. The methods of qualitative researchers on these issues had not been developed to the point where they offered any assurance of their ability to assemble accurate evidence and to test hypotheses. Indeed, in sociology the only qualitative methods receiving much development were for the quantification of qualitative data! The assumption behind, and because of, these developments was that sociology was embarked on a straight-line course of progress towards becoming a science, by virtue of quantitative verifications of hypotheses.

A smaller number of sociologists did take other positions, in their research and teaching, but they began—and still continue today—to use the verification rhetoric in talking of qualitative data (testing, proving, tentativeness, demonstrating, and so forth). One position was "since we are so accustomed to qualitative data, let's verify with such data, as they do with quantitative data." These advocates tried to systematize the ways they collected, assembled and presented qualitative materials. Sometimes they used quantifying techniques, but their systemization was far broader. Virtually every maneuver was accomplished according to precise patterns—for example, how interviews or observation were recorded, coding procedures accomplished, modeled analyses done, and concepts clarified. The path to systematization was guided (as this book has been) by the pressure that quantitative verifications had put on all sociologists to clarify and codify all research operations, no matter what the type of data or the content of the research report.[17]

17. For clarifications and codifications of qualitative methods see, for example, the articles in Richard N. Adams and Jack J. Preiss (Eds.), *Human Organization Research* (Homewood, 111.: Dorsey Press, 1960). The call to codify and clarify all methods, including qualitative research was earlier given in 1949 by Robert K. Merton, *op. cit.,* p. 390.

Another position taken by advocates of qualitative data has been that these data were their media and therefore were still the best and richest for theorizing about social structures and social systems. Also, qualitative method still was the only way to obtain data on many areas of social life not amenable to the techniques for collecting quantitative data. The fascinating fact about people who have taken this stand is that they have continued to generate theories from qualitative data, realizing its importance, and yet they have not explicitly referred to their work as generating theory (or have not described how they generated theory or how it was relevant) because they have been too concerned with formulating their ideas within the rhetoric of verification! In reading their writings, one constantly finds that they make qualifications using the verification terminology, such as "the hypothesis is tentative," "we had only a few cases," "we need more denite proofs in future research," and "we checked this out many times." We cannot evaluate how well their theories were generated, because we are seldom told of what use the theories are in prediction, application and explanation, or what procedures led to suggested hypotheses.

The position of the logico-deductive theorists also became subordinated to the rhetoric of verification. Since they did not use data for generating theory anyway, they supported quantitative verifications as the best way to reformulate and modify their theories. This meant, of course, that they supported the trend in sociology that pointed toward the perfection of their own theories by other men. They could not lose. As we have remarked earlier, they never mentioned the lost emphasis on generating theory, since perhaps they wanted their work to be tested and only slightly modified rather than replaced.

Our position in this book is as follows: there is no fundamental clash between the purposes and capacities of qualitative and quantitative methods or data. What clash there is concerns the primacy of emphasis on verification or generation of theory— to which heated discussions on qualitative *versus* quantitative data have been linked historically.[18] We believe that *each form*

18. In the 1930's, men like E. W. Burgess attempted to mediate between the antagonists, using both types of data in their research. But inevitably they leaned toward the Stouffer-Lazarsfeld position that qualitative data was exploratory in function, thus neutralizing its generative possibilities.

of data is useful for both verification and generation of theory, whatever the primacy of emphasis. Primacy depends only on the circumstances of research, on the interests and training of the researcher, and on the kinds of material he needs for his theory.

In many instances, both forms of data are necessary—not quantitative used to test qualitative, but both used as supplements, as mutual verification and, most important for us, as different forms of data on the same subject, which, when compared, will each generate theory (see Chapter III).

To further this view, we seek in this book to further the systematization of the collection, coding and analysis of qualitative data for the generation of theory. We wish particularly to get library and field research off the defensive in social research, and thereby encourage it. Although the emphasis on qualitative data is strong in our book, most chapters also can be used by those who wish to generate theory with quantitative data, since the process of generating theory is independent of the kind of data used. (See particularly Chapters II and VIII, on theoretical sampling and quantitative data.)

We focus on qualitative data for a number of other reasons: because the crucial elements of sociological theory are often found best with a qualitative method, that is, from data on structural conditions, consequences, deviances, norms, processes, patterns, and systems[19]; because qualitative research is, more often than not, the end product of research within a substantive area beyond which few research sociologists are motivated to move; and because qualitative research is often the most "adequate" and "efficient" way to obtain the type of information required and to contend with the difficulties of an empirical situation. We wish also through this book to provide sociologists with a set of categories for writing their theories within a rhetoric of generation, to balance out that of verification.

19. See James Coleman's discussion of the relative merits of qualitative and quantitative research in analyzing the "working parts of a system," "Research Chronicle: The Adolescent Society," in Philip E. Hammond, *op. cit.,* pp. 190-193, 206. Coleman agrees with us, but he is not aware that the benefits that he suggests for a "comparative quantitative analysis" can also be obtained with a "comparative qualitative analysis," as we shall show in this book.